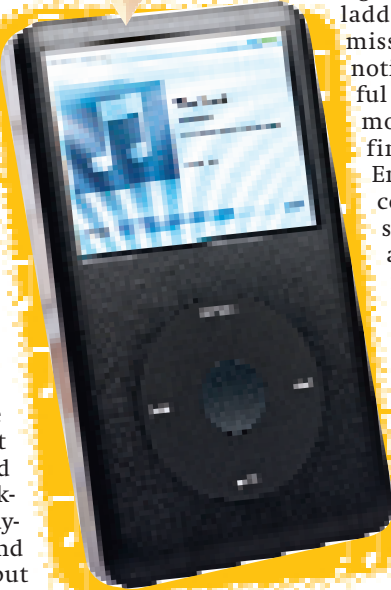


range coupled with a very transparent and tonally accurate upper range means the D2 is at home with almost any kind of music. It does have a whopping output of 74 mW, but surprisingly doesn't seem to drive either the Bose or the Audio Technica cans as well as the iPods do.

The iPod Nano is hardly superior to the D2—it offers slightly higher volumes, (which doesn't mean a lot unless you're a decibel junkie), what is perceptible is a marginally better extension in the lower bass. The Nano also seems to do a little more justice at detailing the higher frequency ranges, but this is a close comparison, and noticeable only if you're looking for it. As far as video playback goes, both the Nano and the D2 have good screens, but the D2 sneaks ahead with greater picture clarity, a slightly larger viewing area and significantly better colour.

The iRiver X20 4 and 8 GB kept very close to the D2 and the Nano as far as sound quality goes. The real revelation proved to be the none other than the exquisitely designed iPod Touch, which simply blew us away with the sheer music quality. If you want absolutely the best sound, this has to be it. The Touch seemed slightly brighter than the Nano, but some more

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Apple iPod Classic 80 GB
80 Gigs of nirvana

time spent auditioning both 8 and 16 GB versions convinced us of their sonic excellence: there was a little more detail high up the frequency ladder that the Nano missed out on. Also noticeable to the careful listener was a tad more texturing to fine guitar-work on Eric Clapton's *Layla*—certain chords sound a little richer and somehow more full bodied. There's also a barely perceptible (but perceptible nonetheless) increase in depth and detail to Charlotte Church's incredible vocal chords in *Bridge Over Troubled Water*. Both the

Nano and Touch offer similar bass signatures, and a nearly similar mid-range—all the micro-improvements seem to have gone into frequencies higher than 4 KHz.

The iPod Touch makes a good video PMP too, with its large and crisp 3.5-inch screen, but the D2 pulls one over here, and makes for a better micro-theatre.

Conclusion

The iPod Touch is an excellent PMP, and offers good value for

its price. After all the hype surrounding the iPhone, this is one player that will satisfy your sense of flair, and you're virtually a show-off for just taking it out of your pocket! As with any sensational product, pricing is always a deterrent and Apple never meant for every aspiring PMP owner to buy an iPod Touch—if music quality means the most to you, and very good video playback capabilities are as important as the large screen and touch-flo, just close your eyes and stop searching. If you decide you can do without the extra screen size and the flash factor, look at the iPod Nano or the Cowon D2. The former is an excellent music PMP and its compactness makes it an ideal workout companion. The D2 is a very different beast—it has a lot of features, and a brilliant screen, and the added advantage of it being touch-sensitive. It's also something of a novelty with the ability to scribble in a notepad—a perfect conglomerate of performance, features and price. And yes, the D2's 4 GB of storage is also expandable thanks to an SD card slot.

We're conferring our *Best Buy* award on the Cowon D2 for its superb music quality and overall brilliant features and functionality. At Rs 11,000, it's quite a bit cheaper than the iPod Touch—although the Touch is more of a lifestyle device than the D2 can ever be. Nonetheless,

Headphones: Do They Make A Difference?

Most definitely! "But how, and will I notice it?" you might ask. Well, good sound is quite like good food, or even a nice car—it's habit-forming, and going back to something archaic after something new isn't an easy thing to do. A simple example—if you listen to any of the award-winning PMPs in this test on their bundled earplugs, you'd go "Wow!" Listen to them on our reference headphones (the Bose Intra Ear, Grado SR60, and the Audio Technica ATH A900), you'd go "Damn! I didn't even know this track had that little sound in it" and "Wow! Listen to that guitar...awesome!" You have just come a little closer to becoming discerning—a trait of audiophiles—those evil men and women who spend more than a third of their disposable income on audio equipment.

Headphones make a resounding difference, and even two very good headphones will sound quite different due to the fact that they have different *sound*

signatures, or in common terms, are endowed by their manufacturers with different acoustic properties. Remember that a headphone is a miniature speaker, with two little drivers, and will respond favourably to changes in the music source, amplification, and basically anything which cleans up the sound signal being fed to it. Most high-end headphones can't even be used with PMPs, simply because such sources don't provide enough juice to properly drive the headphones' drivers. Most earplug-type headphones make do without amplification—they're intended for portable use. If you're serious about sound, ditch the stock earplugs as soon as you can, and buy a decent set of earplugs—we recommend Creative's EP630—which, at Rs 900, is superb value for money. If you want something better, the Bose Intra-ear is available for Rs 5,000—and will give you more clarity in the highs than the EP630.

If you're listening at home and you don't mind something bigger, (like circum-aural headphones), look at the Sennheiser HD201 and HD202—at Rs 1,400 and 1,800 respectively. Stick to known brands and you should be all right. Costlier headphones don't make much sense, because they need a much better source than a PMP is ever going to be. For those who are interested, higher-end models from the likes of Sennheiser, AKG Acoustics and Grado Labs are also slowly becoming available in India. These headphones range in prices from Rs 2,000 to Rs 35,000, and with such a wide price range, there's literally something for everyone.

If you're spending anything over Rs 8,000 for a PMP intended for long music sessions, take our advice and invest in a good set of headphones. Shell out big and cry once, but forever have world class audio at your disposal.

the D2 offers unbeatable features and performance for its price.

The iRiver X20s offer similar features and pricing to the iPod Nano, but don't sound as good, and although the difference isn't very significant, it is noticeable. The Creative Zen 8 GB finds itself up against the wall with the other brutes in this category. Completely outgunned, this PMP cannot really be recommended to anyone, though it's a good device in its own right.

HDD-BASED PMPs

Unlike Flash players—which are mainly geared towards music with a few exceptions taking a stab at a more video-oriented device—HDD-based PMPs have colossal amounts of storage at their disposal, and are geared more towards video-watching than anything else. Chances are HDD-based PMPs will have larger screens, and of course have a larger footprint—something that won't be very unobtrusive in your pocket. Such players are also useful for people who have a gigantic music collection and like to carry all their music with them. Quite honestly, very few people would carry more than 16 GB of music with them, but if you happen to have a 20-odd gigabyte MP3 collection that you want at your fingertips, along with a dozen or so movies, then Flash players aren't going to cut it. Hard drive-based PMPs also have the advantage of cost per GB—which is ridiculously low compared to Flash-based players—comparatively still an expensive storage medium.

Features

One look at the beautiful Cowon A3 duo had us all as excited—while music is definitely cool, what could be cooler than a personal cinematic experience? The screen has got to be as close to the real thing as possible—with a 24-bit LCD that measures four inches diagonally and can display a whopping 16.7 million colours, the A3 is geared towards being a proper video player. Its even got a dual-core processor, so it can play .vob files (DVD movies) without resampling or downsizing! What's more, even 720p is supported—once again a drag-and-drop away. It goes without saying that the A3 plays all other major video formats. Absolutely amazing, considering we've seen some notebooks stutter with 720p content. On the audio front (like its cousin, the Flash-based D2), it supports FLAC files, so diehard audiophiles who constantly complain about the pitfalls of lossy formats can finally hold their peace. The icing on the cake has to be the superb build quality and upmarket look—with pearl white as a base and a dark grey bezel, the A3 is a stunner.

The other large-screen PMP was the Creative Zen Vision W, with an even bigger screen (4.3 inches). Despite the fact that the Creative doesn't seem to have the specifications on paper that the A3 does, it manages to impress with a very simple menu layout, exceptionally good build quality, and a screen that despite displaying only 262,000 colours doesn't look the worse for it.

Apple has upped the storage on their 5.5G iPod Classic to a massive 80 GB, and an even more colossal 160 GB. The fact that the Classic manages to fit in nearly six times the data of the Zen Vision W at nearly half the footprint itself says a

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